

MAN IN CHARGE
Lalduhoma at a public meeting

NOW, THE HARD BIT

MONEY CRUNCH
He will have to tackle the financial mess in the resource-strapped state, which depends heavily on central assistance

ZPM'S UNITY
Maintaining balance and stability within ZPM, a conglomeration of six outfits, will be a challenge

THE BJP FACTOR
Striking a solid relationship with the BJP at the Centre may be tricky, given the party may seek a piece in the state's politics

projects in the first budget. Instead, he has announced austerity measures, including a 50 per cent cut in the staff of all ministers and legislators, including himself, and no new cars or renovation of government residences. Biometric systems have been introduced at state offices to increase productivity.

There will also be a resource mobilisation committee to enhance revenue. Mizoram has been facing massive stress after the previous Mizo National Front (MNF) government introduced prohibition, with the excise revenue drying up. Lalduhoma is unlikely to overturn this decision backed by the Church, whose support is critical for political survival in Christian-majority Mizoram.

NO EASY ROAD

There will be other pressures too. Lalduhoma will have to take on board leaders of all the parties of the ZPM, who often differ on issues. Lalduhoma himself has long been perceived as someone who walks his own path, which, experts say, was why he couldn't stay in any party for long. As a young officer, Lalduhoma was part of the security detail for PM Indira Gandhi, who inspired him to join politics. He played a key role in brokering peace with Mizo rebel leader Laldenga, the MNF chief, and bringing about the Mizo Peace Accord of 1986. In 1984, Lalduhoma travelled to London to meet the exiled Laldenga and recorded his message urging people to vote for the Congress. The message, played out publicly in the state, led to a huge victory for the Congress. Though Lalduhoma himself lost the assembly poll in 1984, he won uncontested in the Lok Sabha election later the same year. But two years after that, he fell out with the Congress, and floated a new outfit, the Mizoram Congress for Peace, which was later rechristened Mizo National Union. It was eventually merged with the People's Conference to form the Democratic Party. He was with the MNF, too, briefly, but split to establish MNF (Nationalist), which was renamed Zoram Nationalist Party in 1997, and eventually merged with the ZPM in 2017.

While Lalduhoma will now have to ensure that he runs a tight ship of his own, there are external challenges, too, particularly from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) at the Centre, which is hoping to expand its footprint in the state. It has already raised its tally from one seat in 2018 to two. Lalduhoma will have to strike a delicate relationship with the BJP—not perceived very positively by the Christian majority in Mizoram—given how heavily Mizoram depends on central assistance.

Handling such a relationship will need deft political skills, and a personal touch. Lalduhoma, say his colleagues, is exceptionally warm personally even as his public demeanour is that of a taskmaster. "In a meeting with our department, he looked unapproachable. But in one-to-one WhatsApp conversations, he was warm and jovial," says an official.

That warmth was on display on December 12, too, when the ZPM leader visited the wife of the late C. Chhunga, the first CM of Mizoram. Five decades ago, Lalduhoma had first stepped into the chief minister's office as a principal assistant to Chhunga. As he begins his journey as the head of that office today, his life seems to have come full circle. ■